

First Read

China Battery Materials

Hungary battery supply chain investment risk assessment - Expert call takeaway

Equities

China
Mining

Hungary realigns with EU policy framework

We hosted Ms. Ruishu Hong from Mingxi Consulting for a discussion on Hungary battery supply chain investment risk assessment. Our key takeaways include: (1) According to the expert, Hungary's new government may have less discretion in allocating investment incentives and to operate more closely within the EU's broader policy framework; (2) Existing Chinese investments in Hungary are unlikely to face material disruption, production should resume once environmental protection requirements are met; 3) new capacity expansion may slow down due to stricter scrutiny and fewer subsidies.

Materials: resumption after environment issue resolved

The expert believes existing Chinese battery materials projects in Hungary, including Yunnan Energy's separator plant in Debrecen ([link](#)), can resume operations once environmental compliance issues are resolved. The wholly owned investment model remains permitted currently, and the expert expects any mandatory change to existing equity ownership would likely face resistance from both company and member states. Overall, operational risks for existing Chinese battery materials facilities appear limited.

Battery: capex slowing down

The EU parliament has stated that Hungary's breaches of the rule of law threaten European values and misuse of EU funds ([link](#)), and the expert expects that Hungary will now realign with the EU's broader policy framework and have less discretion on budget allocation. The expert believes this could slow down battery makers' capex, especially their phase 2 or phase 3 factory ([link](#)), without Orban-era government subsidies and fast-track approvals. We believe this may be negative for battery equipment makers, as new battery projects may face higher costs and longer approval timelines.

Auto: PHEV tariff likely 2027

The expert expects EU action on PHEVs to follow the IAA (Industrial Accelerator Act) progress, most likely in 2027. Production capacity in Thailand serving the EU may remain viable, as exemptions are possible near term, but these are likely to diminish as local capacity is built. Against the backdrop of the EU's growing trade deficit with China, the expert suggests that tariff measures, alongside potential incentives for IP transfer and requirements for local joint ventures, could be considered. These measures are intended to encourage the reshoring of manufacturing activities back to Europe.

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Valuation Method and Risk Statement

We believe the risks inherent to the electric vehicle (EV) battery materials sector include, but are not limited to, the volatile nature of commodity prices and currencies, which may differ materially from expectations. The sector is also exposed to government EV regulations and global policies on climate change, which could significantly impact company/industry performance.

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